
I'm Usually Immune to Inspirational Olympics Stories. Not This One.

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On Monday in Cortina, American bobsledder Elana Meyers Taylor narrowly beat Germany's Laura Nolte in the women's monobob finals [to win her first Olympic gold medal in 16 years of trying](#). The 41-year-old Meyers Taylor is now [the oldest gold medalist ever](#) in an individual Winter Olympics event and only the second Black woman, after [American Erin Jackson](#) in 2022, to win individual Winter Olympics gold. Remarkably, Meyers Taylor has medaled in five straight Olympics; her latest podium finish, her sixth overall, ties her with Bonnie Blair as the most decorated female Winter Olympian in U.S. history. But all of these accolades don't quite capture what is so interesting—and so moving—about her career.

To judge by the heart-tugging features that NBC runs throughout its prime-time coverage, the Milan Cortina Games are chock-full of inspirational Olympians. The narrative logic behind these segments is sound. We all want someone to root for, and by illuminating some of the rockier stretches of the hero's journey, NBC gets you to cheer for an athlete you otherwise wouldn't know or care about.

In the aggregate, though, these segments can start to make viewers feel jaded. In a world riven by sorrow and desperation, it seems cheap and somewhat manipulative to imply that a professional skier returning to competition after suffering a leg injury is a bona fide profile in courage. If everybody's inspirational, then nobody's inspirational. *Oh, look, another 23-year-old who has to wake up early to practice. Big damn deal.*

But this easy and often-justifiable cynicism can sometimes prevent us from recognizing when an allegedly inspirational story actually lives up to the hype—when the catharsis an athlete finds in Olympic competition is directly linked to the pathway that brought them there. In those rare instances, the adversity angle—the frame story that NBC deploys like rock salt on an icy sidewalk—becomes the best and perhaps only way to explain what an athlete achieved, and why that achievement is meaningful.

Take Elana Meyers Taylor. The former [George Washington University softball star](#) has been bobsledding for Team USA across three separate decades, from her 20s into her 40s. There are very few Olympic athletes in any discipline who have excelled at such a high level for so long, in large part because sustaining peak athletic performance over such a span is no easy feat. Doing so requires you to commit to the ongoing training that your sport necessitates, which in turn generally precludes you from pursuing a normal adult career—and all the while, you need to fend off debilitating injury, age-related decline, and an endless supply of younger, more limber challengers.

Meyers Taylor has sustained this level of excellence in, of all things, *bobsled*: a sport that's been inhospitable to Black athletes in general [and to Meyers Taylor specifically](#); that's relatively unpopular in America; and that attracts less money and fewer marketing opportunities than, say, skiing and skating. When I say there's no money in bobsledding, it's not an exaggeration. In November, the U.S. men's team [launched a GoFundMe campaign](#) so that they could afford to put a third sled on the World Cup circuit. "If I don't raise the money, [we're] done," [said U.S. bobsledder Geoff Gadbois](#). "[We] can't compete. It's either I've raised the money, or I'm done for the year."

The campaign raised only 14 percent of its goal. Gadbois is not at the Winter Olympics.

Unlike skating rinks and ski resorts, of which there are a relative plethora, there are only two sliding

centers in the United States, in Park City, Utah, and at the Team USA training center in Lake Placid, New York. In order to train in Lake Placid, you must either choose to live in the Lake Placid area—no, thank you!—or commit to spending a good part of the year there, which in turn makes it hard to hold a regular job or spend time with your family.

Being an American Olympic bobsledder, then, means making immense sacrifice without much in the way of tangible reward. No American bobsledder knows this better than Elana Meyers Taylor. She is the mother of two young sons, 3 and 5, both of whom were born deaf, one of whom was also born with Down syndrome. Her kids travel with her to competitions, where she pulls double duty as both athlete and mother. “I thought it would get much easier as they got older and it has not,” [she recently said](#). “Bigger children, bigger problems.”

So why keep doing it, then? [In an NBC segment](#) titled “Elana Meyers Taylor: My Why,” the bobsledder answered that very question.

“My No. 1 goal in life pre-kids was to win an Olympic gold medal,” she said over b-roll of her son playing with two of her bronze medals. “As athletes, we focus so much on your value being tied to your accomplishments. With my kids, what it’s really taught me is, your value lies in who you are as a person. It’s really important to show them that, regardless of what people say, regardless of what the world thinks, you can persevere through any obstacle you face and go after your dreams.”

In a different context, that closing sentiment might come across as an empty cliché: *Follow your dreams, overcome obstacles, drink Coca-Cola*. But given what we know about Meyers Taylor’s life and career, it’s impossible to be cynical about her message of perseverance. On Monday in Cortina, her first gold medal secure, she sank to the ground and [embraced her children](#) while clutching an American flag. If the Olympic spirit actually exists, it is embodied in moments like this and in athletes like her: grown adults who know what it is to struggle and, in the context of that struggle, what it means to finally succeed.

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